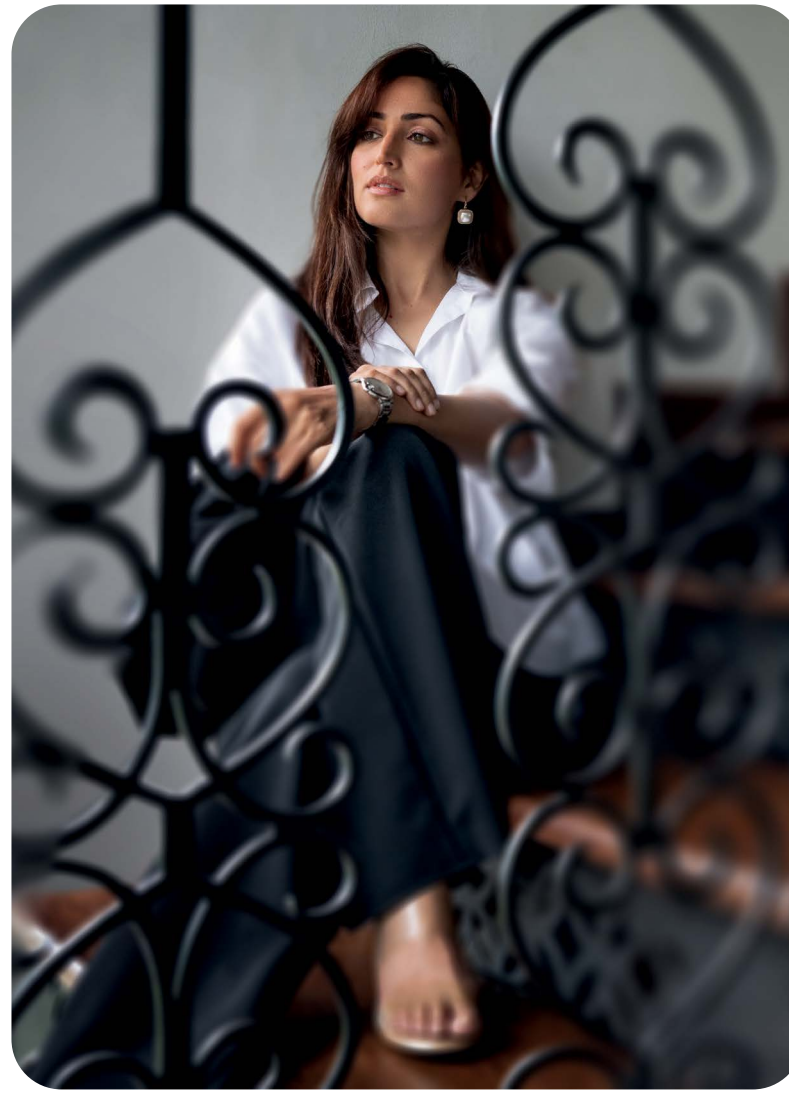


Before producers Aditya and Lokesh Dhar settled on Yami Gautam Dhar to play the part of a steely NIA officer in conflict-ridden Kashmir in 2018-19, there was brief talk of a male actor being better for the film's commercial prospects. "But they wanted a female actor to shoulder this," says Yami. "They didn't think a female officer would not be able to do what a man would in this scenario." That decision stood vindicated as *Article 370* earned Rs 78 crore at the domestic box office. Two years later, vacationing in Mauritius, Yami and Aditya found cause for celebration again, when they heard the movie had not just been named best film at this year's National Award, Yami had also won the best actress honour.

HER INSPIRATION
"My mum Anjali. She has to be the most selfless, loving, strong and emotional person I have met. I can't do anything without her. I run to her for the smallest thing"

In a career spanning nearly 15 years, she had finally earned her first significant accolade. When she started out, with *Vicky Donor* in 2012, her confidence was "at another level", she says. "There was no fear of saying 'no'." Though the film was a critical and commercial success, it didn't open the doors she had hoped it would. Yami worked on some duds and in supporting roles so that she could stay seen and relevant. "The bubble breaks, fear seeps in, you have questions and you realise you are just a tiny drop in this massive ocean." That self-doubt evaporated in 2019, when she delivered two blockbusters—*Uri* and *Bala*. One military thriller, one comedy. Her versatility was clear.

Next year, she will be in the awards conversation again for her work in *Haq*, a drama loosely inspired by Shah Bano's herculean legal battle for alimony. "I wasn't trying to mirror someone's personality," says Yami. "The film encapsulates the plight of so many women.... No matter how much you do, you will be running short. At the heart of it, it's the anguish of a mother." For now, even as she processes the news of her National Award, she realises expectations from her are only set to rise. "The artiste in me will always want to detach from that," she says. "I want to work in the same headspace I was in during *Haq* and *Article 370*. I would still like to feel that nervousness [on set]." ■

—Suhani Singh

WOMAN TO WOMAN
"Health is a very underrated aspect of life. Please give yourself an hour or so every day for you to unwind, connect and work on yourself. Be it yoga, cycling, dancing, whatever. While we are capable of multitasking, everybody needs good health to sustain themselves"